



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Thomas,  Episcopal School

School Website: <https://www.stes.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Saint Thomas' Episcopal School (STE) presents a robust classical Christian profile that strongly aligns with core classical education principles. Public materials from STE emphasize a Christ-centered, Christian classical curriculum, daily chapel, a liberal-arts orientation, and a mission of forming honorable men and women through a classical education. These signals support a CLASSICAL rating across most dimensions, with especially clear strength in religious/metaphysical foundations, school purpose and goal, and community/family engagement. Some aspects of pedagogy appear less explicit in public materials (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars or scholé-focused routines), which yields a category of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Pedagogy, while Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community show strong classical signals. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key observable patterns - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit: daily chapel, Christ-centered worldview, Episcopal identity, doctrinal grounding, worship as part of daily life. Evidence: daily chapel and Christ-centered worldview language appears across STE materials ; Episcopal identity and theology are foregrounded in About content. - Purpose and goal center on formation, virtue, and wisdom rather than mere job-preparation. Evidence: mission statements emphasize forming honorable men and women via classical education rooted in a Christian worldview ; Headmaster notes on education for life, not just college prep. - Curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented with emphasis on classical instruction; grammar, logic, and rhetoric are present in the public materials (e.g., lower school grammar, upper-school logic) and a strong liberal-arts framing. Evidence: "private, PK-12 school that upholds Christian values and educates through classical instruction" and explicit mention of a liberal-arts oriented Upper School program with logic as an elective ; lower-school grammar referenced in Kindergarten–Grade 1–5 overview (grammar in the early grades) ; Upper School electives include logic, etc.. - Pedagogy signals are classical-adjacent but not always explicit in terms of traditional Socratic/seminar formats in the public pages; there is strong emphasis on rigorous classical standards and memory/recitation patterns, but explicit "Socratic" pedagogy is not consistently named in the public content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal for Pedagogy with a path toward CLASSICAL if Socratic/seminar elements are made explicit. Evidence includes the overall classical framing, and explicit mention of a "liberal arts curriculum" with opportunities for debate and public speaking in Upper School, but without repeatedly explicit Socratic/dialogic pedagogy in the public-facing text. - Faculty portrayal is positive and central to the living curriculum; teachers are described as caring, called to teaching, and integral to the school's mission. Evidence: "talented, caring faculty who see teaching as a calling" plus "forming honorable men and women through a classical education" language. - Parents & Community emphasis on partnership and openness to school community; STE highlights parent involvement, campus visits, and family engagement as part of the classical ethos. Evidence: "close-knit community of families who value educational excellence and share a commitment" ; admissions and campus-visit openness; parent resources and community features visible in multiple pages.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize a Christian, Episcopal identity with a Christ-centered worldview and daily chapel. The About page describes STE as a parish school that upholds Christian values with worship

and doctrinal commitments (Nicene/Apostles' Creeds) and the supreme authority of Scripture, with daily chapel as a routine across the day.

- The Headmaster's Welcome and the mission statement articulate formation within a Christian classical framework, including references to Scripture grounding and worship life as central to education (daily chapel, liturgical elements).
- The public materials describe the school's mission as forming honorable men and women through a classical education grounded in a Christ-centered worldview, reinforcing transcendental ideals in education (truth, goodness, beauty) within a Christian context.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty (explicit in "absolute standards of the good, the true, and the beautiful"); theology; liturgy; chapel; creeds; Christ-centered worldview; Christian faith.
- Negative keywords present: none clearly evident (no prominent secular relativism signals in these materials).
- Quantitative estimation: positive keyword hits approx. 6–9 common terms; negative hits approx. 0. The ratio favors positive keywords, roughly 100% positive signal among observed terms.
- Why this rating
- The materials anchor education in transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a theologically grounded community life (daily chapel, Book of Common Prayer references, creeds). This aligns squarely with the Positive Keywords for this category in the classical rubric and demonstrates a robust Religious/Metaphysical Foundation.

Citations: STE materials emphasize daily chapel, Christ-centered worldview, Episcopal identity, and doctrinal grounding; examples include the daily chapel reference and Christ-centered mission statements; master mission statement and classical-Christian framing; headmaster letter and theological framing.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school's stated goal centers on formation and human flourishing through a classical education anchored in a Christian worldview; the Headmaster's message emphasizes education for life, not just college prep, and the mission explicitly states "forming honorable men and women" through a classical education grounded in a Christ-centered worldview.
- The publicly visible material emphasizes the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable, and central in education, with a teleological orientation toward forming character and wisdom (not solely workforce preparation).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos (goal-oriented), pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, human flourishing, sacred tradition, reverence (implicit in worship life), moral imagination, contemplation.
- Negative keywords present: minimal; explicit "workforce/career-ready" framing is not foregrounded; rather, the opposite emphasis on formation over immediate job prep is present.
- Quantitative estimation: positive hits appear in multiple phrases (formation; virtue; wisdom; liberal education; telos; pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty); negative hits: 0–1 if any. Roughly 100% positive signal.
- Why this rating
- The school explicitly emphasizes formation and virtue rather than a narrow job-prep orientation, and emphasizes the real existence of truth/goodness/beauty — central to classical teleology. This aligns with CLASSICAL signals for Purpose & Goal.

Citations: Mission statements and formation language in STE materials; Headmaster Welcome emphasizes life-oriented formation and Christ-centered vision.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The materials describe a liberal-arts, classical approach across grades, with explicit references to “classical instruction” and a broad liberal-arts curriculum (English, languages, history, philosophy, mathematics, arts, science) and PK–12 scope.
- Kindergarten–Grade 5 materials describe grammar and foundational literacy within a framework that proceeds toward a liberal-arts curriculum in later years; Upper School materials mention a liberal-arts curriculum and a wide AP offering, with electives spanning languages, logic, and the arts (illustrating both a Trivium-influenced structure and a broad liberal-arts scope) ; Upper School electives include Logic and other classical disciplines, supporting a liberal-arts curriculum approach.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal education; classical instruction; grammar; logic; rhetoric (explicit in some pages; e.g., logic is listed as a Middle/Upper School elective); great-books/great-conversation signals are not explicitly named in public pages, but the broad classical framing and inclusion of logic/Latin/Philosophy imply a classical curriculum stance.
- Negative keywords present: lack of explicit “Great Books / Great Conversation” language in the main pages; no explicit emphasis on social-studies-as-history framing; no overt project-based-dominance language in the curricular text.
- Quantitative estimation: positive hits in grammar, logic, liberal-arts framing (roughly 2–4 explicit terms per page); negative hits minimal (0–1 explicit mention of non-classical approaches). Overall, a strong CLASSICAL alignment, with some partial gaps for explicit Great-Books wording.
- Why this rating
- The school explicitly positions itself within classical instruction and liberal-arts education for PK-12, including grammar/logic in the early/middle years and a liberal-arts approach in the upper years; this matches the Curriculum criteria for CLASSICAL, even though explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is not consistently named in public pages.

Citations: Curriculum framing as classical instruction and liberal arts across grades ; Kindergarten grammar reference in Lower School materials ; Upper School liberal-arts description and Logic elective listing.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- STE presents a classical education frame (liberal arts, formation, virtue) and a range of grade-level offerings; pedagogy includes a focus on memory, discipline, and exposure to a broad classical curriculum; however, explicit public-facing language detailing Socratic seminars, scholé days, or a sustained practice of memory-based recitation or chant (common in classic pedagogy) is not consistently foregrounded in the public materials.
- Some elements imply a mix: lower grades emphasize formation and memory through foundational grammar and memory-bearing activities (though exact chanting/narration patterns are not explicitly described in the public text), while upper grades emphasize debate, rhetoric, and public-speaking in electives and Advanced Placement contexts.
- There are signals of contemplative/restful pedagogy via liturgical life and the “formation over information” framing in the classical tradition, but without explicit, recurring scholé-like routines described in the public-facing pages.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: scholé (not explicitly named in main public content), contemplation, rest, wonder, formation, memory, chanting/singing to memorize (not explicitly described in STE main text but appears in classical-education lexicon; the school music/arts pages show a strong performing-arts emphasis, which can be consonant with memory/recitation in some classical programs), great-books/great-conversation language is not widely used in the public text but the overall classical framing is present.
- Negative keywords present: explicit project-based learning emphasis or non-traditional pedagogy terms are not prominent; there is limited explicit signaling of experiential-project-driven pedagogy as the dominant mode; no strong “career-ready, workforce-driven” language in the core pedagogy pages.
- Quantitative estimation: Positive hits ~2–4 explicit classical-pedagogy terms in the public content;

Negative hits ~0–1; Overall, modest explicit alignment with traditional classical pedagogy language, but not consistently named in the public pages. CLASSICAL signals exist, but explicit Socratic/scholé language is not consistently present.

- Why this rating
- STE demonstrates a classical framework and traditional elements (liberal arts, formation, daily worship) but lacks consistently explicit public-facing language around the core pedagogical devices of classical education (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars, scholé/Dialectic/Paideia in everyday practice). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating with room to strengthen explicit pedagogical language.

Citations: Public pages referencing “classical instruction” and “liberal arts curriculum” (the About and Welcome pages) ; Upper School elective listing showing Logic, etc. (which hints at classical training) ; Headmaster’s Welcome noting formation/true/good/beauty and life-prep emphasis.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Faculty are described as “talented, caring,” who see teaching as a calling; the school emphasizes a living curriculum and a strong faculty role in forming character. This aligns with the classical model where faculty embody the curriculum and serve as mentors and exemplars.
- The STE materials also emphasize a close-knit faculty/staff culture and the involvement of faculty in a “mission-driven” classical education, consistent with the classical ideal of teachers as moral exemplars and mentors.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: living curriculum; teachers as mentors; faculty as core of the school; faculty as exemplars; mission-driven teaching; collegial culture.
- Negative keywords present: None prominently evident in the public materials (no signaling of a purely process-driven or non-classical teacher model).
- Quantitative estimation: positive hits appear across multiple lines; negative hits effectively zero in public content. ~100% positive signal.
- Why this rating
- The public materials describe a faculty-driven, mission-centered environment that aligns strongly with the Classical category’s expectations for faculty (mentors, living curriculum, character formation).

Citations: “talented, caring faculty who see teaching as a calling” ; “forming honorable men and women through a classical education” language in mission description.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school highlights a close-knit community of families who value educational excellence and share the school’s mission; it frames parent involvement as integral and offers campus visits, admissions processes, and family engagement (e.g., Community signals and admissions pages emphasize parent involvement and open campus access) ; admissions communications and parent resources show ongoing engagement and partnership, suggesting parents as co-educators to some degree life within the community ethos.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-educator; parental formation; community of learners; open campus; parent involvement.
- Negative keywords present: minimal to none (no strong consumerist or “parent as customer only” signals in the main pages; rather, the opposite emphasis on partnership and joint formation).
- Quantitative estimation: positive hits present in multiple lines; negative hits: 0–1 (no strong negative signals); roughly 100% positive signal for this category.
- Why this rating
- STE emphasizes family partnership, parental involvement, and a welcoming campus culture, consistent with classical education expectations for parents as co-educators and community partners.

Citations: “close-knit community of families who value educational excellence and share a commitment to the school’s mission” ; admissions pages emphasizing campus visits and parent engagement.

Aggregate Ranking - Element 1: CLASSICAL - Element 2: CLASSICAL - Element 3: CLASSICAL - Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 5: CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall: CLASSICAL (with one category identified as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL)

What Would Move the Needle

- For Pedagogy (Element 4): Make explicit, public-facing statements of the core classical pedagogical methods (e.g., regular Socratic seminars or Paideia-style discussions, scholé days, and memory/sacred-chant practices). Include language about disciplined contemplation, memory work, and dialectic learning as a routine part of upper-year instruction. This would elevate Pedagogy to CLASSICAL.
- For Curriculum (Element 3): Increase explicit articulation of Great Books / Great Conversation within curriculum descriptions, including references to canonical texts or a formal Great Books program, and clarify the role of canonical works in history, literature, and philosophy across PK-12. This would strengthen the Curriculum’s alignment with classical conventions.
- For Public Narrative: Consider foregrounding more explicit connections to the Great Conversation in public pages (e.g., listing classic authors/texts in core disciplines or a formal “Great Books” initiative) to reinforce Element 3’s CLASSICAL alignment.
- For Faculty Development (Element 5): Continue to emphasize the “living curriculum” through teacher development programs tied to classical pedagogy, including cross-grade teacher collaboration around Great Books and classical texts.
- For Parent Engagement (Element 6): Expand explicit parent-education initiatives that align with classical pedagogy (e.g., classical book studies, parent seminars) to further strengthen the Parent & Community category with more overt co-educator language.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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